5WTS/CMS

From: Section 40 Sec (AS)2a, Room Section 40

MINISTRY OF DEFENCE

Main Building Whitehall London SW1A 2HB

Telephone (Direct Dialling Section 40 ext
(Switchboard)

ENCL NO. 22

(F1)

hile copy

Section 40
Manchester UFO Research Association
Section 40

Your reference

Our reference
D/Sec(AS)12/3

Date
5 July 1988

Dear Section 40

1. Thank you for your letter of 25 May 1988 asking for any information we may have on possible Unidentified Flying Object (UFO) sightings in the Ilkley area of Yorkshire on 1 December 1987. I have searched through our files but regretably can find nothing which relates to the incident you are interested in.

2. However you may find it helpful if I explain that whilst we do receive and co-ordinate some information about UFO sightings, the main concern of the Ministry of Defence is to determine whether or not UFOs present a threat to the security and defence of the United Kingdom. Unless we judge that they do, and this is not normally the case, no attempt is made by MOD to investigate or identify the objects.

3. We have no department which is appointed solely for the purpose of studying reports of UFOs and we have no staff who are employed on the subject full time. This being so we do not have the resources to undertake any further investigation or general survey. The sighting reports we receive, which usually are limited to the brief details of the incident passed on to us by those who witnessed them, are referred to our staff in the departments which are responsible for the air defence of the United Kingdom, and they examine the reports as part of their normal duties.

4. Since our interest in UFOs is limited to possible defence implications we do not carry out full time studies into the UFO phenomenon nor do we have the resources to undertake any indepth investigations. I am sure that you will appreciate that defence funds are fully committed to the continuing security of the UK against, primarily, aggression from the Warsaw Pact countries. This being so we could not justify the use of defence funds on scientific investigations, unless a clear threat to the security of the UK had been identified.

5. Nevertheless it is clear from the reports that we receive that many strange things have been observed in the sky, although we believe that rational explanations could probably be found for most of them. Possibilities which spring to mind include satellite debris re-entering the earth's atmosphere, ball lightning, unusual cloud formations, meteorological balloons, aircraft lights, aircraft at unusual angles amongst others.

6. Although we are able to answer any specific queries you may have about particular incidents which have occurred recently and can let you know whether we have a report on the incident and if so what it contains, I regret that the release of any material on the subject "en bloc" is not possible as, like other government departments all MOD files are subject to the Public Records Act. As you may be aware, this Act states that official files generally remain closed from public viewing for 30 years after the last action has been taken.

7. I hope that you find this helpful.

Yours sincerely

Section 40

From: Section 40

file copy

PROT No. 55

(+1)

MINISTRY OF DEFENCE
Secretariat(Air Staff)2a
Main Building Whitehall London SW1A 2HB
Telephone No: Section 40

Section 40
MUFORA
Section 40

Your Reference

Our Reference
D/Sec(AS)12/3
Date
21 October 1988

Dear Section 40

Thank you for your letter of 13 July 1988 which enclosed a copy of your letter of 6 April 1988.

I was concerned to read that 2 men apparently under the guise of being representatives of the Ministry of Defence visited your witness on 15 January this year. As I mentioned in my last letter, unless we judge that an Unidentified Flying Object (UFO) sighting presents a threat to the security and defence of the United Kingdom and this is not normally the case, we do not undertake investigations or seek to identify unusual sightings. As such we do not, nor do we have any need, to visit individuals to ask them for an account of their experience. I am not aware of any MOD representative carrying out such tasks and must deduce that they were not bona fide officials from the Ministry. In addition, you may find it helpful to know that your description of the MOD identity card which was used on the occasion does not tally with our present design. I hope that this sets the record straight.

Lastly, in response to your letter of 13 July 1988, where you asked for details of Government agencies which might have an interest in UFO research, I regret to say that I am not aware of any Government organisation, other than ourselves, which has an involvement with the subject.

I hope that you will find this helpful.

Sorry that I have not been able to write to you before now.

Yours Sincerely

Section 40

PB

From: Section 40
Secretariat(Air Staff)2a
MINISTRY OF DEFENCE Room Section 40
Main Building Whitehall London SW1A 2HB
Telephone (Direct Dialling) Section 40
(Switchboard)

ENCL No. 73

file copy

Section 40

Your reference

Our reference
D/Sec(AS)12/3

Date
16th December 1988

Dear Section 40

Thank you for your letter of 29 November which referred to the case of apparently bogus MOD representatives visiting a witness of yours earlier this year. As I mentioned in my last letter, we are not aware of any such visits by MOD officials but regret that we have no idea where they might have come from or who they were. Moving to your other point, about MOD identity cards, I would like to clarify matters by confirming that I am not aware of any previous design which matches the description of the card shown to your witness.

I hope that you will find this helpful.

Yours sincerely,

Section 40